

WHAT EARLY CHALLENGES DID YOUR COMPANY FACE?



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When we started Karbonn, our main objective was to offer value for money for our customers. India is a dynamic market and we wanted to understand the mindset of the Indian population to offer the right product to the right set of target audience. We spent a lot of time in understanding the needs of the Indian mobile user, especially those in the Tier-II and Tier-III cities. That's why we started with the Dual SIM phones. This was probably our USP over the others (at the time) especially as none of the other so called global brands offered it and we took off from there. Since inception, Karbonn has grown well. From an annual revenue of ₹1,500 crore in 2011, the company closed FY14 at ₹4,500 crore, of which around 8 per cent came from the export market!

SUDHIR HASIJA

THE CHAIRMAN OF UTL AND KARBONN MOBILES

it's only a matter of time before foreign imports of devices will reduce greatly.

Started in 2011, Celkon Mobiles began by importing handsets from Taiwan, but now manufacture them fully out of their Telangana plant, churning out over two lakh handsets every month – they aim to boost productivity to over 10 lakh handsets per month very soon. A joint venture between Delhi-based Jaina Group and Bangalore-based UTL Group, Karbonn Mobiles had its inception in 2009 and offers a comprehensive portfolio of mobile phones with an array of innovative features, rivalling that of its competitors Micromax and LAVA.

All these four mobile manufacturers constitute majority of the homegrown Indian smartphone companies, and with the exception of Celkon, all other major players (Karbonn, Micromax and LAVA) are slated to start smartphone manufacturing in India itself from later this year.

MIGRANTS RETURN, LOCAL IS KING

For many years, the cream of Indian talent has gone abroad. While Silicon Valley continues to be the crown of the tech entrepreneurship kingdom, it's saturated and overcrowded, giving India the perfect opportunity to fight back and attract its talent back.

Snapdeal was one such invention which seemed destined for birth in the Silicon Valley, but because its founders couldn't get work permit (or so the legend goes), they had no choice but to return to India and start their venture here – and now aren't they glad they did so? Snapdeal.com is fast becoming the best online destination for gadget deals in India. There are many such success stories, and the trend is unquestionable – starting a company in India is a sought after bullet point on any serious entrepreneur's resume in the 21st century. But is the audience here ready for a technology avalanche?

On that question, Shashank ND, Founder & CEO, Practo, perhaps leaves us with the right thoughts to chew on. “Indian consumers have been in the interesting position of skipping several technology generations a few times now,” he says. “For example, we entirely skipped wireline telephony and moved straight to mobile phones, we skipped wired broadband and skipped to wireless as well as pretty much missing the entire ‘computer’ revolution and moving straight to smartphone era. We believe that whether or not consumers understand technology, they have an innate sense of ‘experience’. They sense if a product has been done with care or with carelessness.”

Here's hoping that a lot of Indian innovators, entrepreneurs keep that advice in mind while creating the next wave of world-class tech enterprises right here in India. **4**

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